

mean many new therapies remain unaffordable for a large segment of the population.

In recent reforms, the government has reduced the cost of essential drugs and strengthened cancer care infrastructure across the country. But a 2024 study published in the *Journal of Pharmacy and Bioallied Sciences* that examined the availability and utilisation of essential medicines across states found that availability ranged from 17% to 51%, with stock-out periods lasting between four and 14 weeks. It identified challenges such as inefficient procurement and distribution and pointed out the need for stronger systems to ensure

available and accessible to all,” says Sudarshan Jain, Secretary General, Indian Pharmaceutical Alliance.

The policy challenge is multi-faceted. The National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority has imposed price caps on over 800 essential drugs but there are concerns whether these are sustainable for the industry. Stringent price regulations can sometimes lead to shortages. Another pressing issue is India’s reliance on imports for Active Pharmaceutical Ingredients (APIs); around 70% of these are sourced from China. To reduce this dependency, policymakers are working to strengthen domestic API production through Production Linked Incentive schemes.

Healthcare Ltd, says diagnostics are the foundation of preventive healthcare. With the industry projected to reach ₹2.1 lakh crore (\$25 billion) by FY28, she sees an opportunity to expand access, given the increasing burden of preventable diseases, a rapidly ageing population and limited insurance coverage. “To make healthcare truly essential, diagnostics must be integrated into public health frameworks. Expanding insurance coverage and embedding diagnostic services into government initiatives like Ayushman Bharat will enhance accessibility and affordability,” says Shah.

At present, there is a significant gap in data-driven preventive care, as India lags in integrating predictive diagnostics into its public health policy, which could aid early detection and cost-effective management.

“Strengthening collaboration between policymakers, healthcare providers and the diagnostics industry is crucial to making quality healthcare not just a service but a fundamental right,” says Shah.

Similarly, Anand K. believes that early detection through widespread screening programmes can significantly reduce the burden of chronic diseases and lower treatment costs.

A recent study in *Social Sciences & Humanities Open* highlights the dual crisis of non-communicable diseases (NCDs) in India, impacting both public health and household economies. “Controlling the epidemic of NCDs requires a comprehensive approach. A large-scale initiative for screening diabetes, hypertension, heart disease and kidney ailments in Tier-II and Tier-III towns could bridge the long-standing gap in reliable diagnostic services,” says Arvind Lal, Executive Chairman, Dr Lal PathLabs.

After all, only a healthy India can become a Viksit India. **BT**

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Digital interventions such as telemedicine, AI-driven diagnostics and preventive care present opportunities for expanding access

consistent medicine availability. A 2024 study in *Scientific Reports* that assessed the affordability of essential medicines for non-communicable diseases in India revealed that most medicines cost more than a day’s wage across sectors. The Indian pharmaceutical industry is projected to grow from ₹5.4 lakh crore (\$65 billion) in 2024 to ₹10.8 lakh crore (\$130 billion) in 2030 and ₹37.4 lakh crore (\$450 billion) in 2047.

“In a country as diverse and vast as India, we have a long way to go to ensure equitable healthcare access. As the global health paradigm shifts from illness to wellness, the focus must be on recognising healthcare and medicines as essential goods to make them affordable,

“By strengthening research, building resilient supply chains and ensuring access to life-saving medicines, we can create a future where no individual is denied the care they deserve,” says Jain.

DIAGNOSTICS: THE MISSING LINK

Diagnostics influence 70% of healthcare decisions but account for less than 5% of healthcare spending. The high cost of diagnostic services, particularly in Tier-II and Tier-III cities, limits accessibility. The rise of at-home testing during the pandemic highlighted growing demand but weak regulation around these services remains a concern.

Ameera Shah, Promoter and Executive Chairperson, Metropolis